

FIELD OF VISION | SHARDA UGRA

Saina versus Sania



Prakash Padukone has never been headline-hungry. In 1997, even at the head of a player rebellion, Padukone, India's greatest-ever badminton player, managed to hold his peace and retain his dignity surrounded though he was by the constant clamour of daily controversy. This week, however, the legend offered up a very juicy headline. Padukone was asked to compare the country's two most prominent sportswomen and said, "I don't go by the rankings which can be achieved by picking and choosing the tournaments one wants to play. Saina has beaten more top-rated players than Sania and I would rate her performance higher."

There you go. Now that Padukone has spoken, it's out in the open, this unspoken popularity contest between the two sporting sisters from Hyderabad with their uncannily similar names. Okay, so they are not sisters. Not even, it could safely be said, in spirit. Sania Mirza is the spice girl of Indian tennis, a diva who is as in your face as the forehand that took her to a career-high ranking of 27 in the world. Saina Nehwal, world No. 7 this week, has a much lower profile but is an athlete of simmering ambition, as compelling in her coiled intensity as Mirza is in her flamboyance.

It may seem a natural rivalry but the two actually have more in common than is immediately apparent. Both have smashed through the glass ceiling for Indian women in their sport. Mirza has gone toe to toe with the hardest hitters on the women's tour. Along with polishing her racquet skills, Nehwal is a glutton for the boring part of being a professional athlete—hard, monotonous, physical training

because it is the only way to compete at the top level. In their all-out commitment to physical aggression, they have set the markers for every Indian girl who will play badminton or tennis tomorrow. They have not set the standard; Nehwal and Mirza have, in fact, become the standard.

On the outside, Saina versus Sania makes for a classic cat-fight. In an interview after the Olympics last year, Nehwal had even said she minded being confused with Sania. What came next was to be storyline spoiler: "Sania Mirza is a very sweet person," Nehwal said, "She is very supportive of me and attends every match I play in Hyderabad."

Padukone, it is safe to say, was not trying to light fires or be provocative. He responded to a fairly loaded question by being loyal to his sport.

The fact that Saina Nehwal has fewer endorsements than Sania Mirza is not a reflection on either athlete.

It is a reflection on the fairly vapid standards of the sports marketing environment around them—and of us, the consumers.

So, 'Sania or Saina' is a spurious question. It is not mandatory to pull one athlete down in order to hoist the other. Despite the odds, despite the history, despite the handicaps, what Indian sport has today is Sania and Saina. Because of them, tennis and badminton and how Indian girls will play them in the future, are forever changed.

NEHWAL, WORLD NO. 7, HAS A MUCH LOWER PROFILE THAN MIRZA BUT IS AS COMPELLING IN HER INTENSITY AS THE TENNIS PLAYER IS IN HER FLAMBOYANCE.

NAMED: Nirupama Rao, 58, as India's foreign secretary. She is currently the ambassador to China and will succeed Shiv Shankar Menon. Rao has



earlier served as the high commissioner to Sri Lanka, ambassador to Peru and as the deputy head of the embassy in Moscow.

DIED: Shingara Singh, the last known survivor of the Jallianwallah Bagh massacre on April 13, 1919. He was 113 years old.

WON: By wrestler Sushil Kumar, the gold medal in the German Grand Prix and Greco Roman tournament in Dortmund. He won the 66-kg freestyle event while Rahul Balasaheb Aware bagged a gold in the 55-kg category.

APPOINTED: Indira Jaisingh as an additional solicitor-general. A Supreme Court lawyer, she is the first woman to hold the post.

